was the beginning of a business deal and friendship the French would find rewarding in future.

'SEP would gain much more than what you think,' Grover told them. 'And, have you seen the business opportunity here? If the deal goes through, the European Space Agency (ESA) can sell geosynchronous satellite launch vehicles to India, and make a lot of money. India would otherwise go to the US for these rockets.'

It was a double-edged argument the French couldn't ignore. Grover displayed his selflessness in pushing for the contract by telling SEP that he would not take the commission the company was to give him. Morin agreed to consult the European Space Agency (ESA) and get back. I knew Morin had a soft corner for me. Our friendship had blossomed by the side of the negotiation that went on for three years. I had also impressed him by casually slipping in this bit of information that I was a student of Professor Crocco. Morin's wife, like Crocco, hailed from Italy, and he was a fan of the professor.

Four days after the breakfast, Grover called with the good news. SEP, with permission from the French Government and the European Space Agency, was ready to sign the agreement. India would draw up the contract, the French would suggest changes. The barter deal sounded simple, but we had to be careful while drafting the contract.

That part of the job was left to Seshan, the man of impeccable communication skills. The history of contract writing is punctuated by examples of treaties going kaput or getting misinterpreted to one party's unfair advantage because of a misplaced comma or an incorrect preposition. But perfection was Seshan's forte. He dictated the entire contract draft—about fifty pages—in one go, pausing only for breath and, rarely, for what appeared to be a momentary mental juggling for the right term in a crucial sentence. When stenographer Datta Guru gave him the typed text, Seshan ran a pen through the document, the tip of it touching the paper only a few times to inject a comma or to replace a word. The contract was sent to SEP for its approval, and on 24 August 1974 Seshan signed it on behalf of ISRO.